

2000-2009

The DECADE that changed the world Youth Power

BRAVE NEW Demography

Young people, brought up on success stories and not burdened by cultural inferiority, are happy to be Indian

By Samit Basu |

Do you remember 1985? I do. If you are Indian and reading this, chances are you don't; you probably weren't even born then. So say the statistics—most Indians are young, and getting younger—presumably not as individuals, but as a big, billion-headed, amorphous, ambitious mass that runs on Youth Power. What will they do, these fresh-faced standard-bearers of the new millennium? Like the first amphibians that crawled out of the primeval ooze, turned back and made rude faces at their piscine parents, there's a certain pressure on them to make things better.

Young people everywhere, dashing around armed with Youth Power, shaking up the system, changing things. Like they say in *Battlestar Galactica*—the new one that young people watch—all of this has happened before, all of this will happen again. I used to be one of them. The Youth Powered, that is. Which is not as radical as it sounds, since everyone was young once except A.K. Hangal. Amitabh Bachchan used to be the Angry Young Man. Sachin Tendulkar used to be the walking embodiment of Youth Power. Around five years ago, when the nation was last talking about



young people and how they were going to revolutionise everything—these conversations often happen before elections, when pundits wake up to the startling realisation that there will be first-time voters—I was battling for the other side. I'd written a book in my early 20s; I was even in a few lists of Young People with Potential. A truly terrifying place to be, but I dealt; I skulked inconspicuously, and soon enough younger, leaner, better-looking people turned up to take my place in those lists. Today, as the millennium heads towards its adolescence and the last days of my 20s disappear like rejected Rakhi Sawant suitors, I am no longer Young People, and no one expects me to do anything. I'm old enough to remember VCRs, cassette players and rotating telephone dials, which in the language of

A BLUFFER'S GUIDE

- With an estimated 54 per cent of its population under the age of 25, the country is like an eternal college campus.
- The 15th Lok Sabha has an average age of 53.3. Young people form a huge votebank with 100 million first-time voters in E-2009.

Maturing With POISE



2000 Barista takes off as a youth brand and ushers in a new model for Indian youth to hang out, four years after Cafe Coffee Day began in Bangalore.

2002 Rahul Gandhi returns to India and starts a fresh era in youth politics.

2004 A number of under-35 authors publish their books,

starting a new genre in Indian literature.

2006 Students protest against quotas for OBCs in medical institutions.

2007-08 An INDIA TODAY survey of 2007-2008 reveals that connectivity matters to young people. Mobile and Internet bills constitute about 10 per cent of